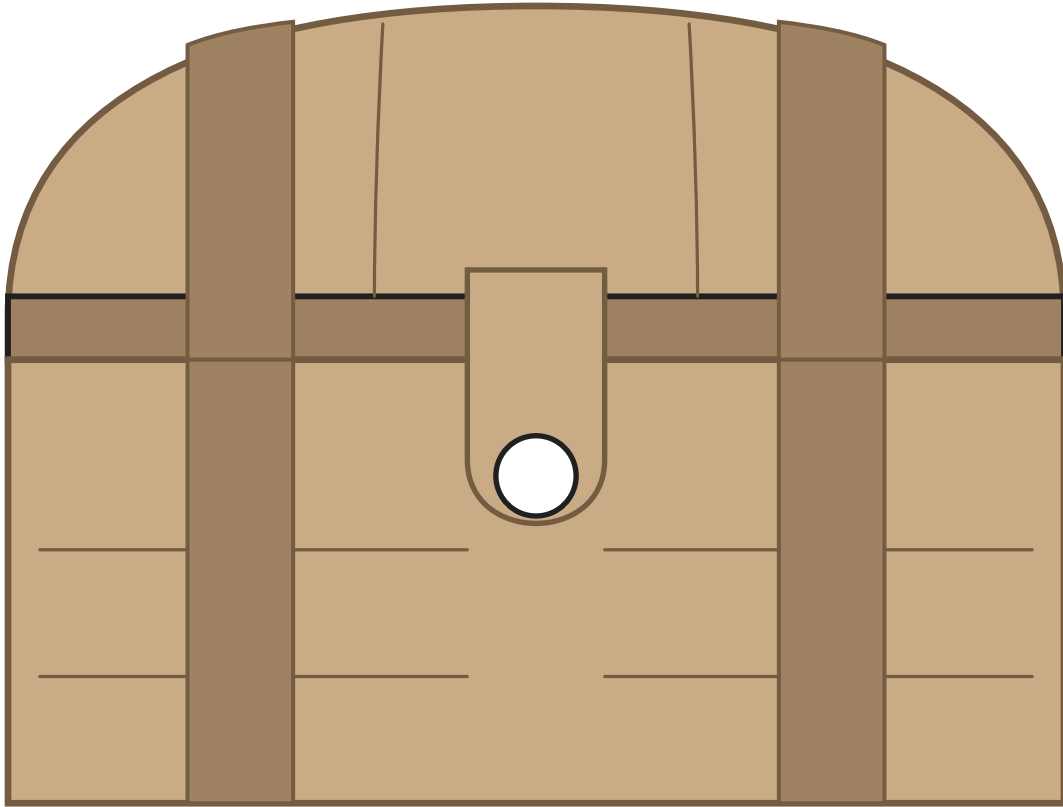




PIRATE TREASURE CHEST

step by step guide



MEASURE TWICE • CUT ONCE • HAVE FUN

Cardboard Studio — our family workshop



What you need

MATERIALS

- Corrugated cardboard — one big sturdy box (single-wall folds best)
- White glue and hot glue
- Cloth tape or duct tape for the hinge
- Paint or markers to decorate (optional)
- Foil or yellow paper for treasure coins (optional)

TOOLS

- Scissors or craft knife (grown-up job!)
- Metal ruler
- Pencil
- Clothespins or binder clips to hold parts while glue dries
- Printer + tape for the template

FINISHED SIZE

10" x 7"

DIFFICULTY

2 of 3

BUILD TIME

1-2 hours (plus drying time)

AGES

6+ with a grown-up

SAFETY: Craft knives and hot glue are for grown-ups. Kids trace, fold, tape and decorate!



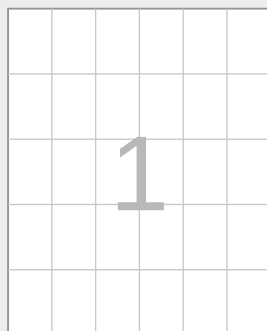
Paper size

INTERNATIONAL (EUROPEAN)

A4



210 x 297 mm
8-1/4 x 11-3/4 in



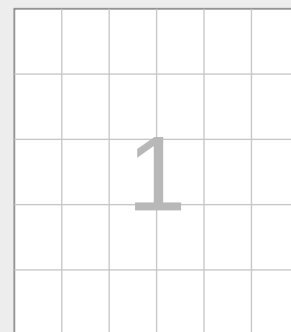
Template part has more height

NORTH AMERICA

Letter size



8.5 x 11 in
216 x 279 mm



Template part has more width



NOTE - printer set up



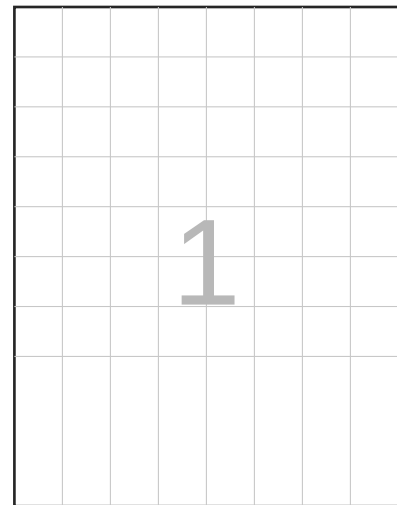
Be sure your printer
is set to print in 100%
ACTUAL SIZE



Print

Page Sizing & Handling

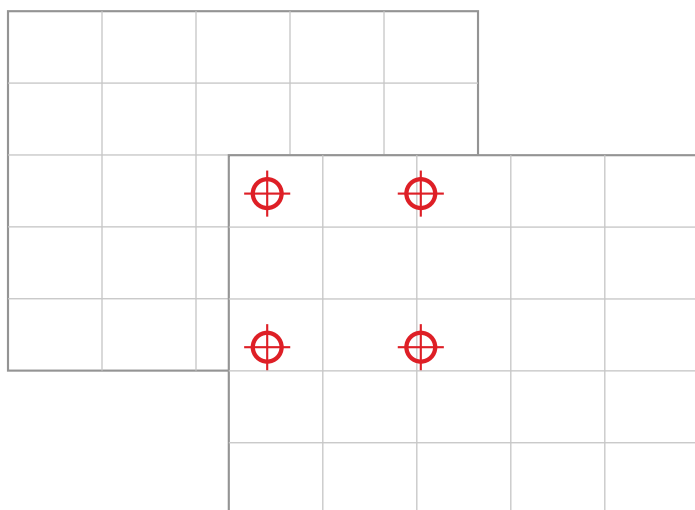
- ☐ Fit
- ☒ **Actual size** ✓
- ☐ Shrink oversized pages
- ☐ Custom Scale: 100%



Page 1 of 12

By default settings the printer shrinks the image to fit its printing area and your template will come out smaller. Each printer has its own paper margin and will not print right to the edge — that is OK: every page includes extra overlap so no detail is lost.

Pages overlap and positioning



① **Overlap**

All pages include an extra margin for overlap, so no details of the template are lost. The exact overlap depends on your printer.

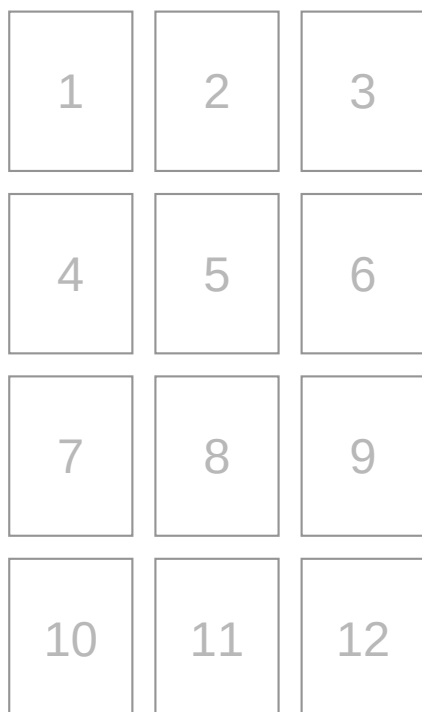
② **1 inch grid (2.54 cm) / 3 inch grid (7.62 cm)**

The grid helps you align the pages perfectly in place. Light lines are 1 inch apart; heavy lines are 3 inches apart.

③ **3x3 inch square**

Overlap the pages until the visible squares measure exactly 1 inch and the heavy lines form 3x3 inch squares — your pattern will automatically align. Tape the pages together.

Your template pages arrange like this:



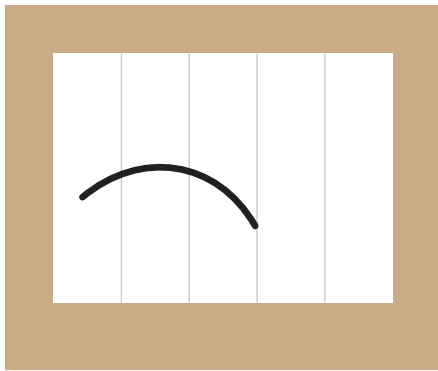
LINE UP THE GRID — THEN TAPE THE PAGES

Tracing

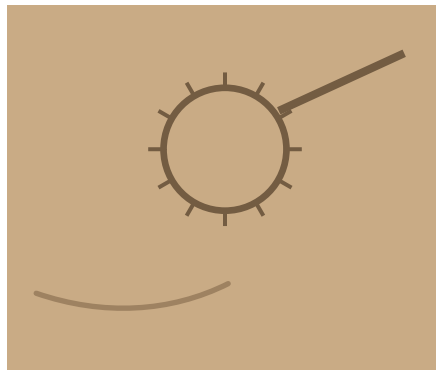
Method 1.

1. Cut Out the Template: carefully cut out the shapes from the printed template using scissors.
2. Secure the Template: place the template pieces on the cardboard and secure with tape or small weights so nothing slips.
3. Trace the Outline: use a pencil or pen to trace around the edges of the template onto the cardboard.
4. Check Your Lines: double-check every piece is traced before removing the template.

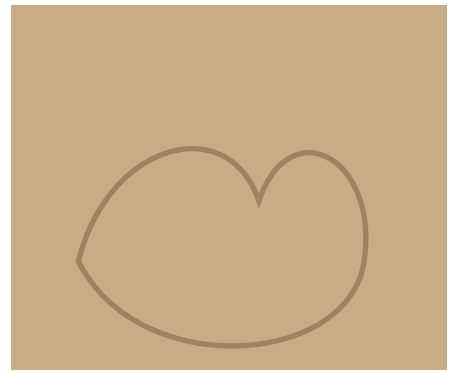
Method 2.



- ① Tape it
and trace it



- ② Tracing tool
a pen with pressure, or a tracing
wheel



- ③ Ready to cut out

NOTE - mind cardboard structure direction

The arrow on each template part shows the direction of the corrugated cardboard flutes. Keep the arrow parallel to the little waves inside your cardboard — parts stay strong and bend where they should.

Tip: the best way to bend cardboard smoothly is to cut slits halfway through on one side. Crease the slits with your fingernail to bend the other way and keep the front smooth.





NOTE - tips and tricks



HOW TO CUT CARDBOARD

PERFECT STRAIGHT CUT

Use a sharp blade and a metal ruler. Cut in 2–3 light passes instead of one hard press.

CUT A PAPER BLEED

Measure your cardboard thickness, cut half through, then peel off the corrugated layer leaving one paper face. Glue sticks much better on the bleed.

CUT A PERFECT CIRCLE

Mark the radius on a cardboard scrap, poke a pin through one end and a pencil through the other — instant compass. Cut just outside the line, then trim.



HOW TO GLUE CARDBOARD

QUICK CONNECTION — HOT GLUE

Fix the panels with tape first, open the joint like a book, run hot glue in the groove, close and tape again. Quick and sturdy for small parts.

BIG PANELS — WHITE GLUE

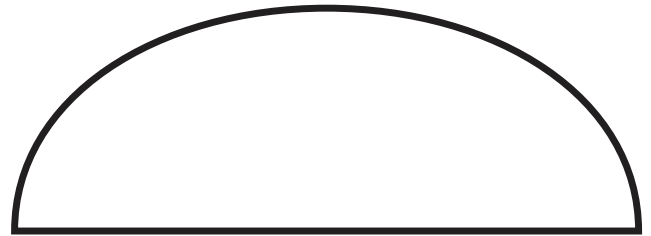
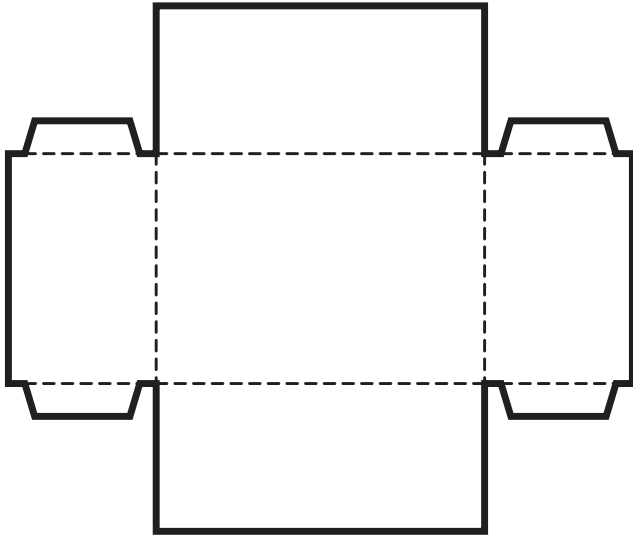
Add a little water to white glue and mix. Spread on the bottom part, lay the top parts like a mosaic so they overlap seams, press under books and let dry completely.

SEAMLESS OVERLAP

Make a paper bleed on the edges, apply white glue on the bottom part and the bleed, connect the matching parts, press and let dry.



Step 1. Print, tape and trace



① The Chest Box — one big cross shape that folds into the whole box.

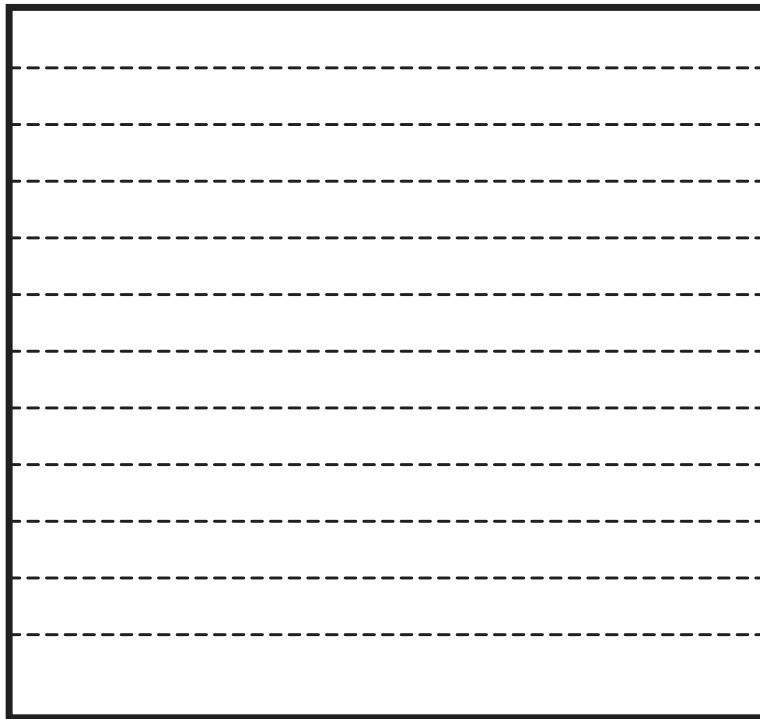
② The Lid Arch End — trace this twice.

1. Print the template at 100% actual size and tape the pages together using the grid.
2. Trace the Chest Box ONCE, the Lid Arch End TWICE, the Lid Wrap ONCE, the Hasp Strap ONCE and the Lock Button TWICE onto cardboard.
3. Keep the corrugation arrows lined up with the little waves inside the cardboard.
4. Poke a pencil dot through the ends of every dashed line so you can draw the fold lines on your cardboard too.

TIP: Trace on the plain side of the cardboard so pencil lines are easy to see.



Step 2. Cut out the parts

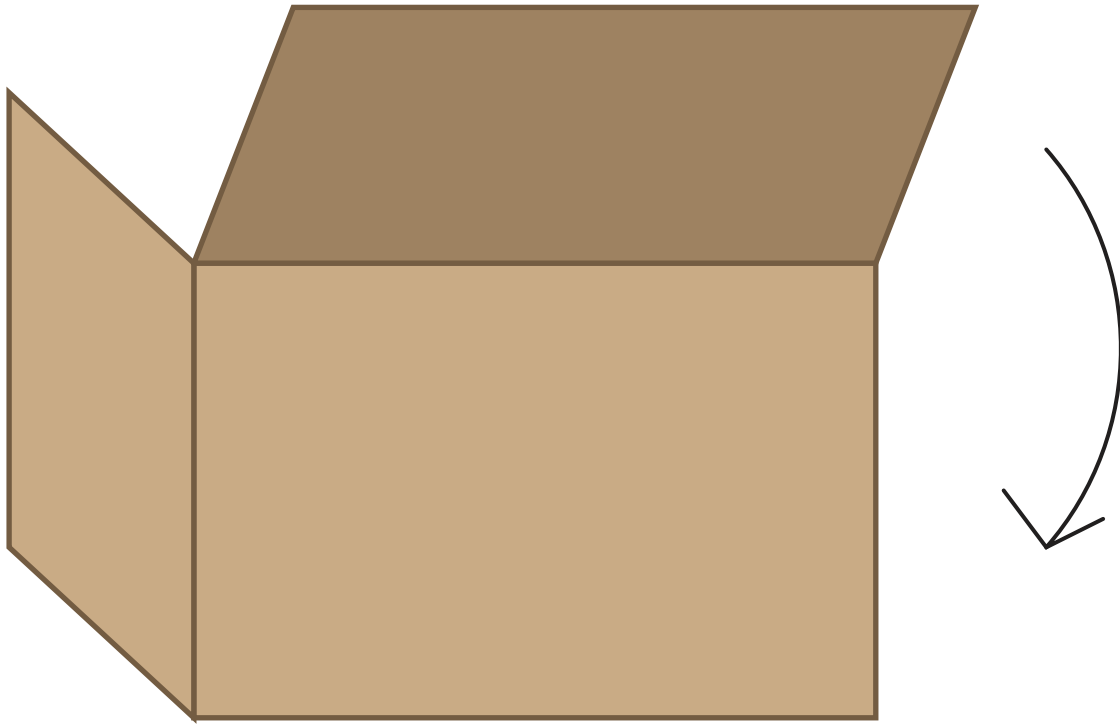


① The Lid Wrap — cut the outline only. The dashed lines get scored, not cut.

1. Grown-up job: cut along all solid lines with a sharp knife and metal ruler, in 2-3 light passes.
2. Cut out the round keyhole in the Hasp Strap too.
3. Do NOT cut the dashed lines — score them lightly (half-deep) with the knife against the ruler so they fold cleanly.
4. Kids can help by holding the ruler steady and collecting the offcuts.



Step 3. Fold and glue the box



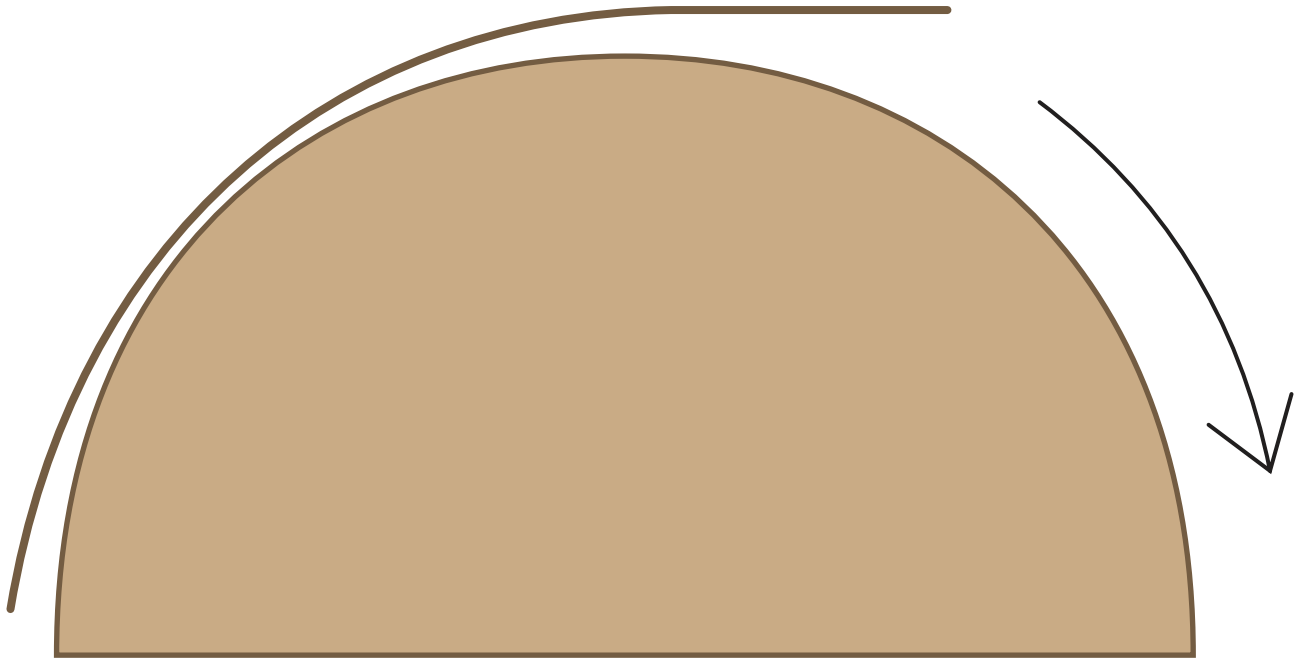
① Fold all four walls up along the scored lines, then fold the little tabs in.

1. Crease every scored line by folding it against the edge of a table or ruler.
2. Fold the four walls up so the pencil lines end up on the inside.
3. Fold the tabs on the end walls inward and glue them to the inside of the front and back walls.
4. Hold each corner with clothespins or tape while the glue dries.

TIP: Hot glue is faster here — but that's a grown-up job. Press each corner for 30 seconds.



Step 4. Build the curved lid



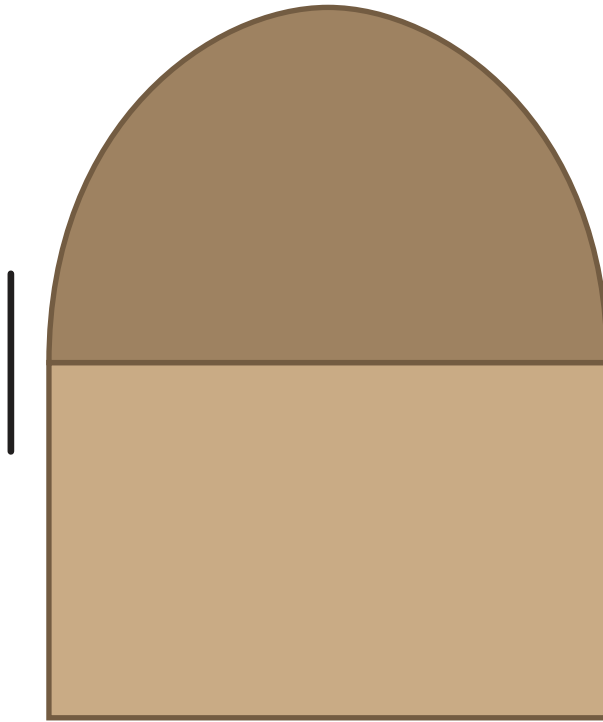
① The scored Lid Wrap bends over the two arch ends like a barrel top.

1. Gently crease each dashed line on the Lid Wrap so the whole sheet curves like a wave.
2. Grown-up job: run a line of hot glue along the curved edge of one Lid Arch End.
3. Starting at a back corner, press the wrap onto the curve a little at a time until you reach the front.
4. Glue the second arch to the other side, then trim any extra wrap at the front so it's flush.

TIP: Line the arches up flush with the ends of the wrap so the lid is exactly as wide as the box.



Step 5. Hinge the lid



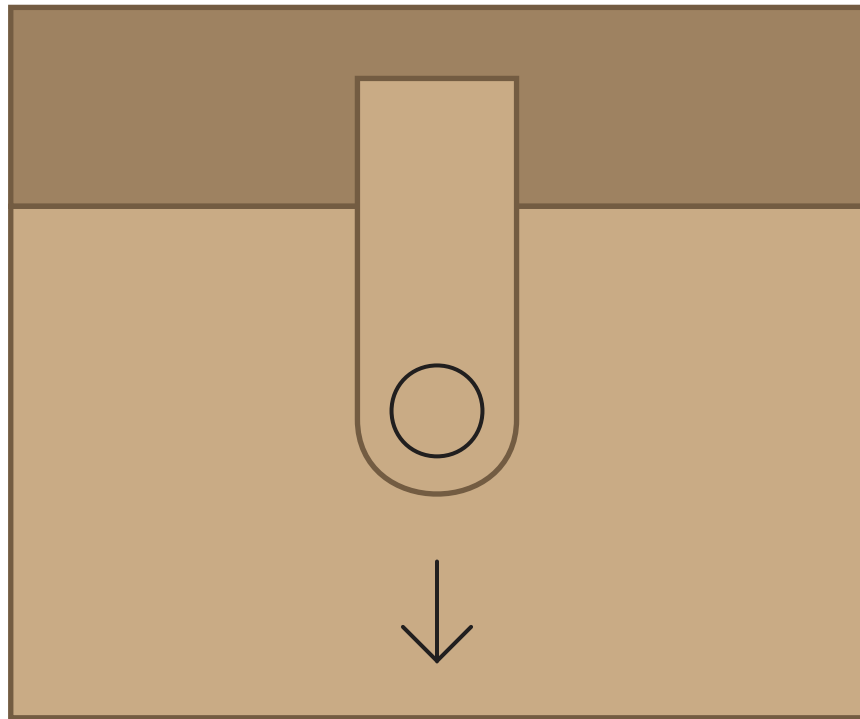
① Tape along the back seam — outside AND inside — makes a strong hinge.

1. Set the lid on the box and line up the back edges exactly.
2. Run one long strip of cloth tape along the back seam on the outside.
3. Open the lid and run a second strip along the same seam on the inside.
4. Open and shut it a few times — a good pirate checks the hinge!

TIP: Cloth tape or duct tape bends thousands of times without tearing — paper tape doesn't.



Step 6. Add the hasp and lock button

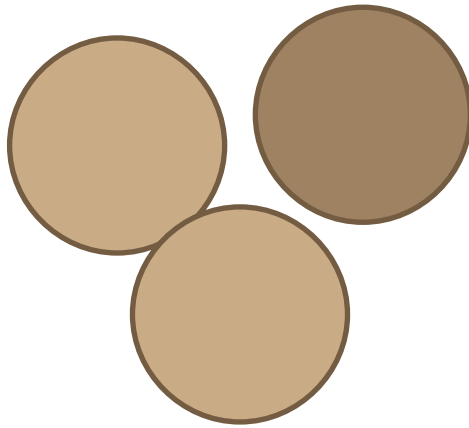


① The hasp folds over the lid edge and its keyhole drops over the button.

1. Glue the two Lock Buttons on top of each other to make one thick button.
2. Glue the short end of the Hasp Strap (above the dashed line) to the middle of the lid front, so the strap folds down over the edge.
3. Close the lid, mark where the keyhole lands on the box front, and glue the button right there.
4. Drop the keyhole over the button to lock your treasure in!

TIP: The keyhole is a little bigger than the button on purpose — that's what makes it easy to lock and unlock.

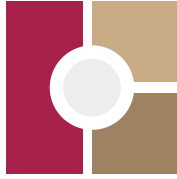
 Step 7. Decorate like a real pirate chest



① Cut cardboard circles and wrap them in foil — instant treasure.

1. Draw or paint wood planks on the box and lid — brown stripes with little dots for nails.
2. Color the straps and hasp black or gold so they look like iron bands.
3. Write your pirate name on the lid, or draw a skull and crossbones.
4. Fill it with treasure: foil coins, shells, jewels — whatever your crew guards best.

TIP: Markers are faster than paint and never warp the cardboard.



CARDBOARD STUDIO

MADE AT HOME, FOR HOME.

This template was designed in our family workshop. Print it, build it, smash it, rebuild it better. Share it with friends — and send us a photo of what you made!

BUILT WITH

Cardboard Studio

Design: Pirate Treasure Chest • 2026